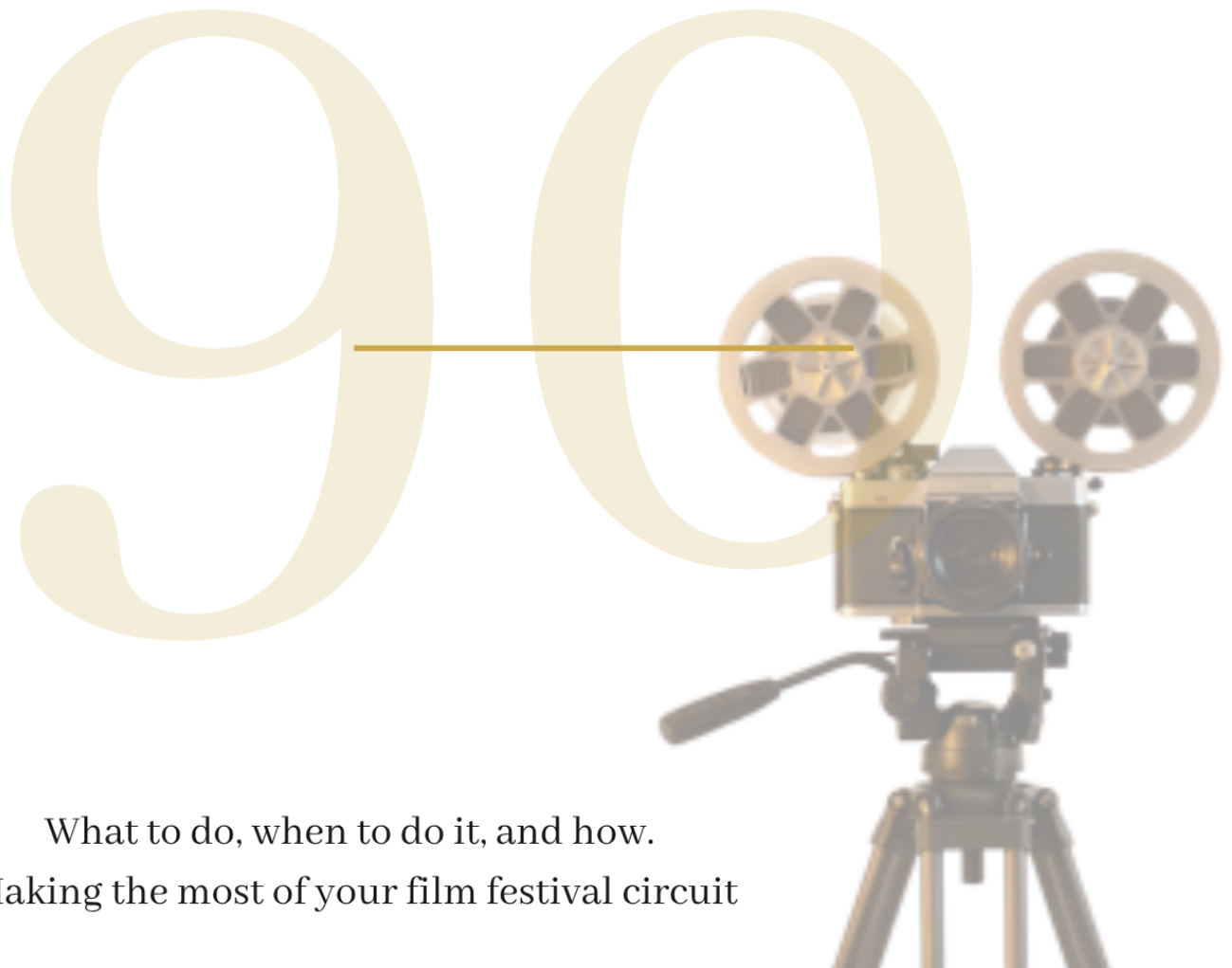


# 90 DAY FILM FESTIVAL STRATEGY



What to do, when to do it, and how.  
Making the most of your film festival circuit

# A Note Before You Begin

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Ninety days. That is how much time separates a filmmaker who shows up prepared from one who shows up hoping.

Film festivals are not passive events. They are concentrated, high-stakes windows where careers accelerate, distribution conversations begin, and reputations, for better or worse, can be established. The filmmakers who get the most out of them are not necessarily those with the best films. They are the ones who did the work, and prepared for a career expanding possibility, before they arrived.

This guide is for documentary and independent filmmakers at any stage of the journey: still building a festival target list, waiting to hear back from submissions, or already holding an acceptance and counting down to a premiere. It is built around a simple principle: every action you take in the 90 days before your festival premiere compounds. Start early, think strategically, and treat this like the exciting and professional opportunity it can be.

The advice here comes from real experience on the festival circuit, not from watching from the sidelines, but from being in the room, in the market, and in the industry conversations that shape what happens to a film after a festival run. Best of all, it comes from being on stage, accepting multiple awards both domestically and internationally (75 and counting!). That's what we want for you too, and that's the reason for this guide.

There are no shortcuts here. But there is a clear map.

## How to Use This Guide

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- Read it cover to cover once, before you do anything else, so you know what's coming.
- Adapt the timelines to your own deadline. If your festival is 45 days out, not 90, compress the phases rather than skipping steps.
- Print and pin the checklists where you'll see them often.
- Share the relevant sections with your team. Not everyone needs all 90 days of detail.
- Use the templates as starting points, not finished products. Make them sound like you, mold them.
- Return to it before every festival. Update your EPK and related materials (trailer) after every win.
- Track your progress against the Master Checklist (near the end of this guide).

## What's Inside

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*Your complete roadmap at a glance, from choosing the right festivals to the work that happens after your premiere.*

| SECTION                             | FOCUS                                                          |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Introduction: Why 90 Days?          | The strategic window explained                                 |
| Phase 1: Before the Clock Starts    | Choosing the right festivals, FilmFreeway, submission strategy |
| Phase 2: Days 90 to 61, Foundation  | Strategy, EPK, poster, trailer, target lists                   |
| Phase 3: Days 60 to 31, Outreach    | Press, programmers, industry, social media                     |
| Phase 4: Days 30 to 8, Momentum     | Screenings, Q&A, meetings, budget                              |
| Phase 5: Days 7 to 0, Arrival Ready | Final checklist, travel mindset                                |
| The Festival Week Playbook          | How to work the room, the market floor                         |
| After the Festival: The Real Work   | Follow-up, distribution conversations, next festival           |
| The 90-Day Master Checklist         | Your running tracker, start to finish                          |
| Quick Reference: Tools & Templates  | Budget tracker, scorecard, contacts, templates, glossary       |

# Introduction: Why 90 Days?

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Most filmmakers start preparing for a festival about three weeks out. They book flights, arrange a hotel, maybe send a few emails. They show up excited, stay busy, and come home exhausted, with a handful of contacts, maybe some business cards, a few nice audience moments, and very little traction toward distribution or their next project.

Why? Nobody prepared them for what an actual festival requires of a filmmaker, or the limitless opportunities it presents.

*A film festival is not the finish line. It is the starting gun for the next phase of your film's life.*

Done well, a festival premiere is a litmus test with an unknown audience, and a media moment. A distribution trigger. A networking accelerator. A proof-of-concept for investors in your next project. A potential accolade and credential that follows your film, and your name, for years. It's an accomplishment.

Done poorly, it is an expensive weekend away.

The difference between those two outcomes is not talent. It is preparation. And preparation takes time. This guide is what you can do with 90 days of it, whether that countdown starts the moment you're choosing which festivals to submit to, or the moment you open an acceptance email.

## ***What time buys you:***

- Press coverage that is researched, pitched, and placed before your premiere, not hastily pulled together the week before alongside other unprepared filmmakers
- Industry outreach that has had time to gauge interest, get responses, schedule meetings, and build context
- Social media momentum that has been building for months, not launched in a panic
- A clear distribution strategy of what this festival offers, and how to identify and ask for it
- A physical and logistical plan that leaves mental bandwidth for the actual conversations that matter

This guide walks you through a tried and tested strategy, phase by phase, week by week, starting with the decision that shapes everything else: every festival offers something, but which festivals are worth your time and money, on this particular film.

## CHOOSING YOUR FESTIVALS

*Strategy before submission. If you already have an acceptance in hand, you can skip ahead to Phase 2 and come back here when you're planning your next submission cycle. This phase is what separates filmmakers who spend their festival budget wisely from those who scatter submission fees across festivals that were never the right fit.*

### STEP 1

### Build Your Tiered Festival Target List

Not all festivals are equal, and not all are right for your film. Submitting to festivals is not a lottery: every submission should be a considered decision. Budget matters, but so does the return on each festival's potential contribution to your film's journey. There is so much more competition now, research each festival.

Your job before you submit anywhere is to build a tiered target list of 30 to 50 festivals that are genuinely suited to your documentary, organized into three tiers.

| TIER                     | TYPE & EXAMPLES                                                      | STRATEGY                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tier 1 (5–8 festivals)   | Prestige targets: Sundance, SXSW, Hot Docs, Tribeca, IDFA, Sheffield | Submit early. These build maximum pedigree and carry the longest odds, worth the fee even at a low acceptance rate. Highly competitive.                         |
| Tier 2 (10–15 festivals) | Mid-level, respected festivals with strong documentary track records | Your primary focus. Stronger acceptance rates, real press attention, and genuine industry presence.                                                             |
| Tier 3 (15–25 festivals) | Niche, regional, and subject-specific festivals                      | Highest acceptance rate. Perfect for building early buzz, adding laurels to your marketing, local press, and community support while you wait on Tiers 1 and 2. |

### The Festival Research Scorecard

Before adding a festival to your list, score it. Rate each factor 1 to 5.

| FACTOR           | QUESTION TO ASK                                             | SCORE   |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| Subject Fit      | Have they programmed similar films in the past three years? | ___ / 5 |
| Prestige Level   | Do distributors, press, and acquisition executives attend?  | ___ / 5 |
| Audience Size    | How many attendees? Do they fill seats for documentaries?   | ___ / 5 |
| Geographic Reach | Is it in a market relevant to your film's audience?         | ___ / 5 |

| FACTOR              | QUESTION TO ASK                                         | SCORE   |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| Cost vs. Return     | Is the submission fee proportionate to the opportunity? | ___ / 5 |
| Personal Connection | Do you know anyone there? Have you submitted before?    | ___ / 5 |

#### ★ WHY THIS STEP MATTERS

*A festival scoring 18 or more points across these six factors is a priority submission. Below 12, reconsider it unless the entry fee is under \$30, at that price, the worst case is a small loss, and the best case is a programmer relationship you didn't expect.*

## STEP 2

### Set Up FilmFreeway Like a Professional

FilmFreeway is our number one choice for submission and research. The primary submission platform for most festivals worldwide. Your profile is your first impression on a programmer before they've even opened your film. Treat it like a business listing, not an afterthought.

- Complete every field: logline, synopsis, stills, credits, and links. An incomplete profile reads as an unfinished film.
- Branding. Use the same poster, stills, and synopsis language across every submission, so programmers and your own materials stay consistent. Make every moment an opportunity to raise awareness for your film.
- Keep your screener link current and tested. A broken link is the fastest way to be passed over.
- Track every submission's status in one place. You will lose track otherwise, especially once you're submitting to 20 or more festivals. Always budget for festival submissions in your initial film budget.

## STEP 3

### Build Your Submission Calendar & Strategy

Once your tiered list exists, turn it into a working calendar. This is the unglamorous, spreadsheet-driven work that prevents missed deadlines and wasted fees, and it pays for itself many times over.

- Map every deadline, for every festival on your list, to one shared calendar. Enlist your team if you can.
- Set a reminder two weeks before each deadline, not the day of.
- Identify 'Early Bird' discount windows. They can save you 20 to 30 percent per festival, it adds up.
- Track submission fees against your total festival budget as you go, not at the end.
- Note exclusivity and premiere-status rules for every festival before you submit. Accepting one can quietly disqualify you from another.

- Group submissions by region where possible, for travel planning down the line.
- Note which festivals allow resubmission of a future cut, and which do not. Which are Oscar aligned.
- Track average response timelines, typically 6 to 12 weeks, so you know when to expect to hear back and when a follow-up is reasonable.
- Flag any festival with a market or industry program attached. Those are worth extra weight in your scoring.

#### ◆ **MARKETING A FILM AND MAKING A FILM**

*Marketing and distributing your film are equally as important as making your film, these are 2 separate, but vital phases. This is no time to be shy. If it is not your forte, get comfortable with feeling uncomfortable for the duration. If you really can't face it, or don't have the skills, but you do have the funds, then hire someone. From experience, there is no outside company that will be as passionate or as dedicated about getting your film seen and licensed as you are. It's just a fact. You must decide if you want to raise more funds and hand it off or learn a new tool. This is where AI can be your friend in reaching out on your behalf.*

## FOUNDATION

*Strategy and materials. You are not promoting yet. You are building the infrastructure. Rushing this phase, or not tackling it, is the most common and costly mistake filmmakers make.*

### STEP 4

### Define What You Want from This Festival

Before you send a single email or book a single flight, answer these questions honestly:

- What is the primary goal of this festival run? Distribution? Press? Future funding? Industry credibility? Audience building? Social impact contacts? Networking? The correct answer: all of the above.
- Who specifically do you want to connect with? Which distributors, which companies are aligned with your film from their previous releases? Which commissioners, other filmmakers, press, or impact partners?
- What does success look like 30 days after the festival ends?
- What do you need to have in hand when you leave? New contacts. Meetings confirmed. Coverage published, deals in discussion? A confidence from having aced a festival and you're ready for the next.
- Do you have all the materials needed to accompany you? EPK? Poster? Screener and trailer (and back ups on BluRay/DVD or thumb drive, yes, still a thing) readily accessible? Business cards? Elevator pitch?

Clarify your direction, create a list, share it with your team, and use it as your strategic north star.

#### ★ WHY THIS STEP MATTERS

*Filmmakers who cannot articulate what they want from a festival tend to drift through it. You will be surrounded by other filmmakers who do have a plan, who know to identify and meet programmers, journalists, and industry figures. Every conversation is an opportunity, but only if you know what you want from it. Luck is often just opportunity meeting preparedness.*

### STEP 5

### Know Your Film's Strategic Position

Not every film is in the same position heading into a festival. Your strategy depends heavily on where your film stands:

| YOUR FILM'S STATUS                   | WHAT THIS FESTIVAL SHOULD DO                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| World premiere, seeking distribution | Generate industry buzz, secure distributor meetings, create a press record, galvanize an audience |



| YOUR FILM'S STATUS                        | WHAT THIS FESTIVAL SHOULD DO                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Post-premiere, building momentum          | Accumulate awards and recognition, expand audience, support ongoing distribution conversations |
| Already distributed, collecting accolades | Community engagement, grassroots screenings, impact partnerships, expanding audience awareness |
| Seeking funding for next project          | Establish credibility, network with funders, executive producers and co-producers              |

Your press materials must be complete, professional, and ready to send before you begin any outreach. This is non-negotiable. A journalist or programmer who requests materials and receives a rough cut of your poster and a three-paragraph email will not prioritize covering your film. This will give the impression that you are unprepared, disinterested, or not invested in making the most of their festival, and they might focus on those who are.

Your EPK is your film's passport. Programmers, press, distributors, and partners all ask for it. It should exist as a shareable PDF and a Google Drive or Dropbox folder with every asset neatly organized. It can always live on a secure server that only you have the password for, it should never be, “yes, I’ll get that to you”. You’ll have lost their attention by then and they’re on to the next filmmaker.

### ***Your EPK must include:***

| EPK SECTION           | WHAT TO INCLUDE                                                                                                         | COMMON MISTAKE TO AVOID                                           |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Film Overview         | Title, runtime, format, language, completion date, logline                                                              | Missing the logline entirely                                      |
| Director's Statement  | 300–500 words on why you made this film, personal voice                                                                 | Too long, too academic, no emotion or vision                      |
| Production Notes      | How it was made, key challenges, what's unique                                                                          | Reads like a press release, not a story                           |
| Director Bio          | 100–150 words, third person, credits first, personal last                                                               | First person, no credits, too casual                              |
| Cast / Subject Bios   | 50–100 words each, photo included                                                                                       | Missing, programmers want faces to names                          |
| Crew Bios             | DP, editor, composer, 50 words each for key crew                                                                        | Too many names, not enough context                                |
| Press & Reviews       | Quotes from screenings, reviews, or notable viewers                                                                     | Empty section, use audience quotes if needed                      |
| Production Stills     | 8–12 high-res (300 dpi), captioned, horizontal orientation                                                              | Low-res, watermarked, or portrait orientation                     |
| Technical Specs       | Aspect ratio, resolution, audio format, subtitles                                                                       | Buried or missing, festivals need this, confirm with your editor. |
| Key Credits & Laurels | Director, producer, cinematographer, editor, composer, writer, key subjects; laurels page updated as the run progresses | Laurels page not updated after a win or an acceptance laurel.     |
| Poster & Links        | Print-ready poster, trailer link, password-protected screener link                                                      | Sending a rough draft poster or an untested link                  |

**⚠ THE SCREENER PROTOCOL**

*Your screener is a professional trust document. It should be watermarked, password protected and sent only to verified press and industry contacts. Piracy is still a thing. Do not make it publicly available. Do not link it on social media.*

*Watermark the film clearly with, 'This screener is numbered, and provided for review purposes only, not for distribution.' Add your copyright information too.*

**STEP 7****Nail Your One-Sheet & Poster**

Your poster is your film's face to the world. It appears on festival websites, in program guides, on social media, and at screenings. A weak poster signals a weak marketing effort before the film is even seen. Everyone talks about thumbnails – we often forget as filmmakers that one day our film will just be a tiny visual on Apple or Netflix. So make it easy or compelling at that small scale too.

| DO                                                                                                                          | AVOID                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hire a graphic designer if your budget allows (roughly \$200–\$500) AI has multiple tools to help if you're short on funds. | Doing it yourself if this is not in your wheelhouse.                                                 |
| Use one dominant, compelling image                                                                                          | Multiple fonts                                                                                       |
| Make the title legible at thumbnail size                                                                                    | Crowding the main poster with crew credits                                                           |
| Include a tagline under the title                                                                                           | Skipping the 200x300px thumbnail test, does it still read?                                           |
| Leave room for laurels to be added later                                                                                    | Skipping feedback from non-filmmakers before finalizing. These are potentially your paying audience. |

**STEP 8****Prepare Your Trailer, Screener & Video Assets**

You need several video assets before you submit anywhere, and each serves a different purpose at a different stage of the festival journey.

| ASSET            | LENGTH         | PURPOSE                       | WHERE USED                  |
|------------------|----------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Full Screener    | Feature length | Festival review               | FilmFreeway, private link   |
| Official Trailer | 2–3 minutes    | Press, partners, social media | Website, YouTube, EPK       |
| Teaser / Sizzle  | 60–90 seconds  | Quick hook, social sharing    | Instagram, TikTok, email    |
| Festival Clip    | 3–5 minutes    | Specific pitch moments        | Distributor meetings, press |

Not all press is useful press for a documentary. You want coverage that reaches the people who matter for your film's next phase: distributors, funders, broadcasters, and serious audience members. Think strategically. Build two separate lists.

### ***Press Targets***

- Documentary-specific publications: Documentary Times, Real Screen, Hot Docs Blog, IDA Documentary Magazine, Filmmaker Magazine, Film Threat, and similar outlets that feature documentary reviews
- Subject-specific media: if your film is about conservation, target environmental journalists. If it covers social justice, target interested organizations. Reverse engineer your film's subject matter to find the outlets whose audiences will care.
- Festival-specific media: every major festival has its own press connections. Research who covered the festival last year and reach out to them directly.
- Local media in the festival city: local TV, radio, podcasts, and print cover festival films, especially if you have a local connection. A crew member who is a local, or a subject in your film who is from the area, is a marketing asset worth using. Get creative to find connections between your film and the festival. Local press love to highlight these kind of connections.
- Connect with festival staff and ask for recommendations on who to contact locally. Local bars, restaurants, and businesses near your screening venue are often willing to display your marketing materials. Festival staff are gems for word of mouth. Social media is great, but physical marketing in bars and restaurants wherever your potential audience hangs out is priceless.
- Podcasts in your theme, local podcasts to the area, and YouTube channels with documentary or film audiences are an obvious connect. Then go further: if your film is about clean water, have you approached water companies for sponsorship or product placement? If it is about dog loyalty, have you approached pet stores, vets? Reverse engineer your film's subject to find unconventional sponsors and partners.
- Offering experiential moments in return for sponsorship has proven productive in marketing campaigns. A private screening for a company's employees, with the filmmaker available for Q&A, is a genuine value exchange. Think about something you need, that perhaps is not financial, that you could ask for in exchange? Is it a large company who can ask their employees to help promote the film in exchange for a private screening. Whether that's on their socials, or via emails to local friends and family. Get creative.

### ***Industry Targets***

- Distribution and sales companies that have handled documentary films in your subject matter. Research what they have acquired recently. Finding the other person's win to match yours will always garner better results. Every distributor wants to find the next hit
- Streaming commissioning editors: research what platforms are actively acquiring in your genre. Some commissioning agents publish what they are looking for, often not in places accessible to independent

filmmakers, but they are out there. Try contacting larger ones such as ITVS, BBC, and PBS directly to ask if they will share their briefs.

- Social impact production companies: Firelight Media, Concordia Studio, Impact Partners, are three of the most active. Each has distinct programs and mandates. Research them and approach the right one for your project.
- Educational distributors if your subject has curriculum relevance: Swank Digital Campus, Films Media Group (Films on Demand), Docuseek, and Alexander Street Press (ProQuest) are the four major platforms. Getting placed in any one of them generates recurring annual licensing revenue
- Impact producers and NGO partners if your film has a social change agenda
- Broadcasters, particularly PBS, BBC, CBC, Arte, and Al Jazeera documentary units

For each contact, note: name, title, organization, email, how they prefer to be contacted, and what you know about their recent acquisitions or coverage. After any meetings, note what was said, how they responded, and what they are looking for. The clearer and more detailed your notes, the easier your follow-up work will be. This meeting may not resonate for your current film, but you'll make others and every meeting can be turned into a future connection and opportunity.

## OUTREACH

*Your materials are ready. Your list is built. Now you begin the methodical work of making contact. This phase is about planting seeds. Not pitching, not selling, but beginning real conversations.*

### STEP 10

### The Press Outreach Campaign

Documentary press outreach has a rhythm. It is not a blast email. It is a sequence of personal, specific, well-timed contacts. Growing your network compounds throughout your career and is one of the most valuable ways to spend time. People come and go in all positions relevant to marketing and distributing your film, so continually growing and updating your contact list matters.

#### *The three-touch sequence:*

- Awareness email (Days 60 to 50): a brief, personalized note introducing your film and announcing your festival premiere. No attachments. After referencing their accolades if any, or why you chose to reach out to them specifically; just the logline, festival, dates, and an offer to send a screener. If you have won anything, or have notable interviewees in the film, lead with these.
- Screener offer (Days 49 to 35): follow up with your press kit attached and a secure screener link. Keep this short. Journalists are busy. Make it easy to say yes. Generally, do not send attachments unless asked to, for several good reasons, most of which protect the film. Change the password once it's been viewed.
- Reminder and angle (Days 34 to 22): a final note with a specific story angle, a hook that connects your film to something in the news or a timely conversation, or something they've written or are passionate about. Give them a reason to cover your film, not just your festival screening.

#### *Who to contact, and when:*

| CONTACT TYPE                | WHEN TO REACH OUT           | WHAT TO OFFER                                                                 |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Film critics & reviewers    | 8–10 weeks before screening | Screener, press kit, one-on-one interview with director, cast member of note. |
| Niche / subject-area press  | 6–8 weeks out               | Story angle focused on the issue, not just the film                           |
| Local press (festival city) | 4–6 weeks out               | Local angle, filmmaker hometown, local subject connection                     |
| Podcasts (film + subject)   | 6–8 weeks out               | Director interview, cast member of note, advance screener access              |
| Social media influencers    | Ongoing from Day 60         | Early access screener, shareable content assets                               |

| CONTACT TYPE                        | WHEN TO REACH OUT               | WHAT TO OFFER                                   |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Industry press (Variety, IndieWire) | Only after acceptance is public | Exclusive interview, distributor interest angle |

**⚠ THE MOST COMMON PRESS OUTREACH MISTAKE**

*Filmmakers send one long email with everything attached and wait. Journalists receive hundreds of pitches. The ones that get covered are the ones that are easy to understand, easy to access, and timely. Three short, well-spaced touches work better than one comprehensive email. Bonus suggestion is to write the email in a manner that the recipient can almost repurpose word for word when pitching it within their company. Do their job for them, they'll be so happy!*



This outreach is different from press. You are not pitching for coverage. You are initiating a professional conversation that may eventually lead to a deal.

***Your opening email to a distributor or commissioning editor should:***

- Be short, under 200 words, do not ramble, read it to someone you trust if you feel unsure
- Name the festival and screening date specifically
- Describe the film in one to two sentences: subject, tone, and audience
- Include one comparable film they have handled or acquired, which shows you have done your research
- Offer a screener and/or an in-person meeting at the festival
- Have no attachments on the first contact, just a clean, informative and precise email

*Your goal with the first email is one thing only: to get a yes to a screener or a meeting. That's it. Do not try to close a deal in an email. It is tempting to go all in while you have their attention, but you want to create a relationship if possible, and an in-person connection can be a lasting one.*

Follow up once if you do not hear back. Do not follow up more than twice before the festival. You will have the opportunity to connect in person at the festival itself.

***Your pitch email, broken down:***

| LINE                | PURPOSE                                      | EXAMPLE                                                                                                        |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Opening hook        | One sentence that makes them need to read on | "Every year, 300,000 veterans return home to silence."                                                         |
| The film intro      | Title + what it is + why it exists           | "[TITLE] is a feature documentary exploring..."                                                                |
| The credential line | Why you, why now                             | "The film has screened at [Festival] has been accepted at [Festival] and won [Award]."                         |
| The ask             | Specific, easy to fulfill                    | "Given the success of [similar themed film they put out] I'd love to send you our screener for consideration." |
| The close           | One clear call to action                     | "Simply reply to this email, I'll send the link within the hour."                                              |

**STEP 12****The Programmer Relationship**

The festival programmer who selected your film is one of the most valuable relationships you have during this period. They chose your film. They believe in it. They want it to do well, because it reflects on their programming. Ask if you can have a Q&A after your film. Sometimes it's not feasible due to time commitments between screenings and clean-up of theatres, but it does add programming for their festival. Usually, they'll try to accommodate you with this request. Just don't let it go over; you can take it into the lobby if it runs long.

Do not neglect this relationship. Reach out to thank them personally. This is not a task for colleagues. It should be the filmmaker or lead producer. Ask them who they think you should connect with over your film. Ask if there are other industry guests attending who might be interested. Ask who is on the press list. Ask if there is anything you can do to help promote your screening. They would love for your film to be licensed at their festival, that's gold for future submissions, festival prestige, not to mention their socials.

This is not a transaction. It is a professional relationship. Respect it and it will serve you well.

**STEP 13****Social Media Strategy**

Your festival run should have a deliberate social media arc, not random posts, but a planned sequence that builds anticipation and reaches new audiences. The worst time to start building a social media audience is the week your film screens, if you haven't started, start now. If that's on your plate, plan it out, and use AI apps to plan and schedule these posts so you aren't distracted later in the process.

| PERIOD        | SOCIAL CONTENT FOCUS                                                                                                         |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Days 60 to 45 | Announce the premiere. Behind-the-scenes. Why this film, why now.                                                            |
| Days 44 to 30 | Subject awareness content. Clips, stills, filmmaker perspectives, behind-the-scenes moments.                                 |
| Days 29 to 8  | Countdown. Preview coverage. Audience engagement: where to watch, how to follow.                                             |
| Festival week | Live updates. Q&A moments. Audience reactions. Photos. Behind-the-scenes live clips.                                         |
| Post-festival | Coverage roundup. Thank-you posts. Next screening announcements. If you won, exploit that win — it is a huge accomplishment. |

***Content ideas that actually work for documentaries:***

| CONTENT TYPE       | DESCRIPTION                                                             | FREQUENCY |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Subject Spotlights | Short stories about your film's subjects — why they agreed to be filmed | Weekly    |

| CONTENT TYPE           | DESCRIPTION                                                   | FREQUENCY        |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Behind the Scenes      | Production stills, bloopers, candid moments from filming      | 2x / week        |
| Why This Film, Why Now | Your directorial perspective on the issue — builds trust      | Monthly          |
| Fact Posts             | Statistics or facts related to your film's subject matter     | 2–3x / week      |
| Audience Testimonials  | Reactions from early screeners — video clips preferred        | After screenings |
| Festival Countdown     | Countdown graphics to submission deadlines or screening dates | Per festival     |
| Press Wins             | Reposts of any coverage, reviews, or shoutouts                | As they happen   |

One practical note: tag the festival in every post. Tag other filmmakers and films you are excited to see once you're at the festival. Festivals often repost filmmaker content, and that amplification reaches exactly the audience and industry contacts you also want to reach.

## MOMENTUM

*You have been planting seeds for 60 days. This phase is about harvesting what has grown and preparing your on-the-ground operation.*

### STEP 14

### Confirm Your Screening Details

Contact the festival directly to confirm:

- Exact screening time, venue, and room, and whether this has changed since you were notified
- Format requirements: DCP, ProRes, Blu-Ray, or other. Confirm they have received your file
- Whether captions or subtitles are required and have been confirmed. Very important
- Q&A logistics: how long, who moderates, where you stand. Bring water — the excitement, and sometimes fear, of speaking after your film can make your mouth much drier than you anticipate, so always have water on hand for you and anyone else from your team
- Whether a filmmaker introduction is expected and how long. Have something ready to text to a staff member that lists your career highlights and sets the film up if they are introducing you. Prepare one for yourself that you can read, if you're not as good 'off the cuff.' Do not leave these vital moments to fate. The audience votes for best documentary

#### ★ AUDIO IS MORE IMPORTANT THAN VISUALS

*Your audience will forgive poor visuals over poor audio. This is a proven fact, and the margin is not small, it is by a landslide. Do not err on the wrong side of this. Best to have both be in excellent shape, but if one is subpar, let it be visuals. We had this problem on an early film of ours where auto focus was used instead of manual and blown up to 35mm. Let's just say it wasn't optimum in a few key scenes. Fortunately, our audio was stellar. That film went on to win 20+ awards at festivals around the world!*

#### ⚠ NEVER ASSUME, ALWAYS CONFIRM

*Screening schedules shift. Rooms change. Technical formats get lost in handoffs. Contact the festival technical team directly, not just the programmer. Get their contact details, phone and email. Confirm receipt of your DCP or screener file two to three weeks prior to your screening. Ask for a technical rehearsal, if one isn't offered, always push for one. Films play differently on*

*different screens. Do not just tech check the first five minutes of the film. Ask the projectionist to scan through and play at different intervals to check the quality throughout.*

*Always have a backup screener with you on Blu-Ray or USB. Never leave anything to chance when it comes to your screening. Things happen. Be prepared.*

The post-screening Q&A is not an afterthought. It is a public performance, and for many audience members and industry attendees, it is the moment they decide whether they trust/like you as a filmmaker. These are the people who will or will not be voting for your film as part of the Audience Award. They will hopefully love your film. Give them a reason to love you as a filmmaker, too.

Do not be afraid to share a mishap during production or from the film's journey, one that you were able to overcome. Everyone loves a comeback story. The audience has a lot of choices with the number of films screening at any given festival. Sometimes it comes down to who they enjoyed most in the post-screening Q&A.

Always have a point you want to get across in a Q&A. Don't just wait for questions; perhaps you want to share a highlight or something special coming up. Now's the time.

***Prepare for these questions. What they're really asking is in parentheses:***

| LIKELY QUESTION                       | WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING                              | YOUR APPROACH                                                                           |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Why did you make this film?           | Tell me something personal. Make me trust you.          | Have a 60-second answer that includes a personal, specific reason.                      |
| How long did it take?                 | How committed are you? Is this a passion or a paycheck? | Be honest and specific about the timeline and what it cost you personally.              |
| What was the hardest part?            | Were you challenged? Did you grow?                      | Be specific. Share one moment that tested your commitment. Vulnerability earns trust.   |
| What do you hope audiences take away? | Do you have a point of view, or just footage?           | Lead with emotion, then action. Be clear about what you want them to feel and do.       |
| What's next for the film?             | Can I help? Where is this going?                        | Have a clear answer: festival circuit, platform, community screenings, or distribution. |
| Hostile or provocative question       | Testing how you handle pressure.                        | Stay calm, acknowledge the question, answer honestly, and redirect to the audience.     |
| How much did your film cost?          | Curiosity, sometimes a test.                            | You do not have to answer this question (see note below).                               |

On the budget question specifically: if your film looks like a million dollars but you made it for under \$250K, you might not want anyone to know that. Let them think it cost more than it did, it just means you're an excellent filmmaker to get more on the screen than the actual budget would indicate.

*It is perfectly acceptable to say: 'We are keeping that under wraps until after we sell or license the film.' Or be playful: 'We love this question. How much do you think it was made for?' Make the audience allies to the independent filmmaker's journey. Enjoy this time with them, while you're making points and sharing more about the film and what's next.*

Practice your answers out loud. Not to memorize them, but to find the version that is honest, specific, and brief. Your answers should rarely exceed 90 seconds unless it is truly a story worth telling. The audience wants a conversation, not a monologue.

*One rule: end every answer by returning the energy to the audience. Always thank them for coming to support your film, and how much it means to you that they did. They always have other choices.*

**STEP 16****Prepare Your Festival Meetings**

By now you should have confirmed meetings, or at least warm conversations, with several press and industry contacts. In the weeks before the festival, do the following for each:

1. Research what they have done recently: acquisitions, coverage, deals.
2. Prepare two to three specific talking points about why your film fits their mandate.
3. Bring a one-pager: a single printed sheet with your film's logline, synopsis, festival dates, contact info, and a QR code linking to your press kit.
4. Know what the ideal outcome of the meeting is and how to ask for it. Practice with friends beforehand if you are nervous.

*The most useful thing you can do in a festival meeting is listen. Ask questions. Find out what they are looking for. Then tell them how your film fits their needs.*

**STEP 17****Build Your Festival Budget and Logistics Plan**

Festival attendance is expensive if not managed carefully. Build a realistic budget before you book anything. We have a free festival cost calculator at [Documentary411.com](http://Documentary411.com), and the table below covers the key line items to plan for.

| EXPENSE CATEGORY               | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Flights                        | Book 6 to 8 weeks out for best pricing. Confirm luggage allowance for any equipment or materials you're bringing.                                                                                                                                                                           |
| Accommodation                  | Festival hotels fill fast. Book the moment you are accepted. Stay within your budget, near the festival hub. Think Airbnb, VRBO, condos for rent — we once rented a mansion on the beach for four nights that slept ten because it was cheaper than ten hotel rooms. Think outside the box. |
| Festival badge / accreditation | Some festivals provide free badges for accepted filmmakers. Confirm this before paying.                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Meals and per diem             | Budget \$40 to \$100 per day per person as a realistic floor. Always have an amount set aside to take executives and potential contacts out for coffee, drinks, or a meal. Filmmaker tents often have snacks, drinks, and sometimes light meals.                                            |
| Ground transport               | Lyft, local transit, or car hire. Research your festival city in advance.                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Printed materials              | One-pagers, postcards, business cards, flyers. Consider bringing, or sending ahead, a one-sheet or poster to be positioned outside your screening room, if possible.                                                                                                                        |
| Shipping                       | If shipping a DCP or materials, build in two to three weeks minimum.                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |



| EXPENSE CATEGORY | NOTES                                                                     |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Emergency fund   | Always hold 15% of total budget in reserve for emergencies and surprises. |

### ***Itemized cost worksheet, with real ranges***

*We have a more in-depth, digital festival calculator you can use on our site; [Documentary411.com](https://documentary411.com) You can also use this version if you want dollar figures to plan against, not just categories. Fill in your actuals as you book.*

*You do not need a publicist, you do not need to throw a party, but these are additions that can make your film stand out over other films and garner attention. I personally believe that the best film wins, but when there are two or three contenders, being the friendliest, or most personable or generous, can land.*

| EXPENSE CATEGORY              | ESTIMATED COST    | ACTUAL COST | NOTES                             |
|-------------------------------|-------------------|-------------|-----------------------------------|
| Submission fees, Tier 1 (×6)  | \$360–\$600       | _____       | Early bird = save 20–30%          |
| Submission fees, Tier 2 (×15) | \$450–\$750       | _____       | Watch for fee waivers             |
| Submission fees, Tier 3 (×20) | \$200–\$400       | _____       | Many are \$10–\$20                |
| Poster / one-sheet design     | \$200–\$500       | _____       | One-time cost                     |
| EPK design / formatting       | \$100–\$300       | _____       | Or DIY with Canva / Gamma / AI    |
| Screener hosting (Vimeo Pro)  | \$240/year        | _____       | Required investment               |
| Travel to top 2 festivals     | \$800–\$2,000     | _____       | Book early                        |
| Accommodation (per festival)  | \$400–\$900       | _____       | 3–5 nights avg.                   |
| Business cards + postcards    | \$50–\$150        | _____       | 500 of each minimum               |
| PR / publicist (optional)     | \$1,500–\$5,000   | _____       | For top festivals only            |
| Social media ads (optional)   | \$200–\$500 / mo. | _____       | Festival countdown ads            |
| TOTAL ESTIMATED               | \$3,700–\$11,100  | _____       | Across a typical submission cycle |

## ARRIVAL READY

*The final week before your festival. By now, all the heavy lifting is done. This phase is about consolidation, making sure nothing falls through the cracks, and arriving in the right headspace. Lists, lists, lists, and check them more than twice.*

### STEP 18

### The Final Week Checklist

#### ***Work through this before you travel:***

- ☐ Press kit confirmed complete and hosted on a shareable link. Printed copy for backup.
- ☐ Screener link tested: password works, video plays, watermark visible
- ☐ All confirmed meetings in your calendar with contact details
- ☐ Festival screening time and venue confirmed in writing
- ☐ Technical delivery confirmed with festival tech team
- ☐ Printed one-pagers packed, minimum 35 copies
- ☐ Business cards packed if printed. Phone-to-phone sharing set up if digital
- ☐ Festival badge and accreditation confirmed
- ☐ Airline tickets, hotel confirmation, and address saved offline
- ☐ Contact number for festival staff including publicist or guest liaison saved
- ☐ Outfit or presentation clothes sorted. You will be photographed.
- ☐ Emergency contact numbers saved
- ☐ Print map of festival: where the filmmaker tent or room is, where your film plays
- ☐ All passwords for screener, press kit, and social accounts accessible offline

#### ***14 days out — final confirmation checklist:***

- ☐ Reconfirm screening time, venue address, and tech check appointment with the festival
- ☐ Confirm your DCP has been received and tested by the festival's technical team
- ☐ Send 'reminder' social posts about screening times with links to get tickets
- ☐ Brief any cast, crew, or subjects attending on Q&A talking points
- ☐ Prepare thank-you remarks for the end of the Q&A — name the festival and its staff
- ☐ Pack business cards, postcards, and printed one-sheets

- ☐ Charge all devices; bring backup battery packs
- ☐ Screenshot the festival schedule and venue maps — don't rely on wifi
- ☐ Set Google alerts for your film title for the week of the festival
- ☐ Send a personal email to any press contacts confirmed to attend
- ☐ Add your own
- ☐ Add your own
- ☐ Add your own
- ☐ Add your own

This is worth saying plainly: festivals are exhausting. They are loud, social, stimulating, late-night, early-morning environments. The filmmakers who perform best in them manage their energy carefully. Excellent for extroverts, more challenging for introverts. Plan accordingly.

- Schedule downtime into your day, not as a luxury but as a necessity. Eat real meals. Drink plenty of water. Carry snacks. Sleep when you can.
- Protect the two hours before your Q&A. Do not book meetings immediately before your screening, unless it is a major connection — this is why you came, get laser focused.
- Be a team player. Attend other films. Watch what is being made and meet the filmmakers. It keeps your perspective sharp and makes you a better conversation partner. There is a high likelihood you will see these same filmmakers at other festivals.
- Seek out crew members from other films. Connect with DPs, directors, editors, writers, and producers. Working with friends is the best. It is also advantageous to be able to refer fellow filmmakers for work.

♦ **ONE THING MOST FILMMAKERS FORGET**

*Enjoy your screening. You made this film. People are watching it for the first time. Marvel at this achievement. Sit in the room if you can. Listen to their honest reactions. All the highs and lows of preproduction, production, post, marketing, and the festival route comes down to this moment. Be present for it.*

# The Festival Week Playbook

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*You are here. The work shifts from preparation to execution.*

## How to Work the Room, Without Working the Room

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The filmmakers who make the best impressions at festivals are not the ones pressing the most business cards into the most hands. They are the ones who are genuinely curious, present in conversations, and generous with their time and attention. Not every conversation should start and end with your film.

That said, there are practical habits that separate professionals from first-timers:

- Arrive early to your own screenings. Introduce yourself to programmers and other industry attendees before the room fills. Thank audience members for choosing to attend as they enter, take the time to interact, if you're not too nervous, and ask them why they chose to attend.
- Stay for the Q&A of every film you attend. The conversation after a screening is where real connections form. You can also learn from experienced filmmakers how to make the most of a Q&A session.
- Ask more than you pitch. 'What are you working on?' is more interesting than 'Let me tell you about my film.' 'What challenges have you navigated?' opens doors.
- Follow up the same day. Send a brief email the evening after a meeting while it is fresh. Do not wait until you are home. Leave a lasting personal connection where possible.
- Keep a running log of conversations: names, organizations, what you discussed, and what the next step is. You think you will remember in one to two months, but with each festival the memory fades. The more detailed your notes, the more helpful they will be when you reach out after the festival.
- Research who will be attending before you go and have a clear 'ask' ready for the right moment.
- Set three specific meetings as a minimum goal, and bring physical postcards, not just digital links.
- Show up to panels even when your film isn't there. Be kind to festival staff, they have more influence than first-timers expect.

## The Market Floor, If Your Festival Has One

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Some festivals, including IDFA, Hot Docs, Sundance, and Sheffield, have active market floors where distribution and co-production conversations happen in a structured environment. If your festival has a market, here is how to use it:

- Register for market accreditation separately from festival accreditation. They are often different badges with different access and may come with an additional fee. If you can afford to attend, and you never have before, you'll find it invaluable for how this side of the business works.
- Walk the floor before you start taking meetings. Understand who is there and what they are buying. Listen to conversations. You will be astounded by what you can learn.

- Look for office hours or open meeting slots with commissioning editors. These are often publicly scheduled and underused by filmmakers.
- Attend any party you can get into. Make it a point to walk away with at least one new contact.
- The market cafe and hallways are where the real conversations happen. Be visible and approachable. Wear a name tag with your name, your position, and your film. Make it as easy as possible for people to approach you.

## Your Screening Day Protocol

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- 1 Arrive at the venue at least 45 minutes before your screening.
  - 2 Introduce yourself to the projectionist and confirm your DCP or file is loaded correctly.
  - 3 Introduce yourself to the festival programmer or host who will introduce the film.
  - 4 Be in the room when the lights go down. Your presence matters.
  - 5 Be easy to locate. If anything happens with the film and they need to find you, or need another screener, you will want to head up to the projectionist before the audience leaves thinking it's an unresolvable technical issue.
- For Q&A: stand where you can see the whole room. Breathe. Take your time answering.
  - After the Q&A: be available for further questions outside your screening.

*Audience members who want to talk to you afterwards are among your most valuable connections. They are also the ones responsible for voting on the Audience Award for Best Documentary. Many have social media accounts and might want to share an insider story about the making of the film to their followers.*

Thank everyone: the festival, the audience, and above all, the programmer, before you leave. Every time. They will most likely be programming the festival next year.

# After the Festival: The Real Work

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*The festival is over. Now comes the phase that most filmmakers handle worst: the follow-through.*

## The 72-Hour Follow-Up Window

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You have 72 hours after a festival ends to follow up with maximum impact. After that, the window starts to close. People return to their offices, their inboxes, and their other priorities.

### ***In that window:***

- Send personal follow-up emails to every meaningful contact you made. Reference something specific from your conversation to spark their memory.
- Send a brief note to any press contact whose coverage you know is coming. Thank them for attending and offer to answer any additional questions.
- Post a festival wrap update on social media. Thank the festival, your team, and your audience; tag the festival and any filmmakers you connected with, or films you loved.
- Update your press kit with any awards or recognition received. Did you receive favorable press? A single strong sentence from a review can be added to your marketing materials immediately.

#### ★ ONE OF OUR MOST SUCCESSFUL FILMS

*One of our films won over 20 festival awards during its festival run, sweeping all three awards in its category at one festival. Despite that astounding success, we still had one nasty reviewer call our lead protagonist a 'charmless gas bag!' Update your materials with the wins. Let the rest go.*

## Distribution Conversations: How to Move Them Forward

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If a distributor or commissioning editor expressed interest, here is how to handle the conversation professionally:

- Do not rush this connection. Interest is not an offer. Treat it as the beginning of a conversation. Exciting, but nothing in writing yet. All serious offers are in writing.
- Send a follow-up with your film's one-pager and a fresh screener link within 48 hours.
- Ask for a call to discuss their interest. Do not negotiate by email. You may not be the right person to negotiate. This might be a fellow producer, your attorney, or your agent.
- Before any call, write down your ideal outcome and your walk-away point. Know what rights you are willing to discuss and which you are not.



- Every distribution offer should be reviewed with a lawyer. Yes, lawyers can be expensive. The right lawyer is worth their weight in gold. Ask fellow filmmakers who they trust and get a referral if you don't have your own.
- If you do not have distribution representation, this is the moment to research whether a sales agent could be useful. Get all costs upfront and understand them fully. This is where filmmakers make their biggest mistakes. Know what you are signing, and again, reach out to an attorney if you are out of your depth.

*The single most common mistake after a festival is silence. Filmmakers wait to be called. Industry professionals expect to be followed up with.*

## Next Festival Decisions

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If your film wins a festival, expect to receive invitations from other festival programmers. This is excellent for you both. They benefit from inviting a film that was clearly a festival darling, so that puts people in seats, and you save on admission fees, which can rack up fast.

If you win, post your winning laurel on every element of your film's presence: website, trailer, social media, screeners, marketing materials. As you continue to each festival the strategy compounds. Every screening is a building brick. Every review is an added asset. Every award strengthens your negotiating position, and informs your next press outreach.

### ***Before your next submission cycle:***

- Review what worked and what did not from this festival run. Ask yourself how you can improve, and update your master plan for the next festival.
- Update your press kit and all materials with new credits, coverage, reviews, and laurels.
- Revise your industry target list based on who showed interest and who did not.
- Reconsider your premiere strategy. Understand what premiere status you still hold and how it affects your options.
- Return to Phase 1 of this guide, your tiered festival list and research scorecard, and rebuild it for the next round armed with everything you just learned.

# The 90-Day Master Checklist

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*Use this as a running tracker. Check each item as you complete it.*

## Phase 1 — Before the Clock Starts: Choosing Festivals

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- ☐ Build tiered festival target list (30–50 festivals across three tiers)
- ☐ Score each festival on the Research Scorecard; flag anything 18+ as priority
- ☐ Set up or refresh your FilmFreeway profile
- ☐ Build a shared submission calendar with deadlines and Early Bird windows

## Phase 2 — Days 90 to 61: Foundation

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- ☐ Define your festival goals in writing
- ☐ Identify your film's strategic position
- ☐ Perfect your elevator pitch: your film in under one minute
- ☐ Complete production stills selection (minimum 10)
- ☐ Write or update your press release
- ☐ Write long and short synopses and your film's logline
- ☐ Write director's statement
- ☐ Finalize credits list and crew/cast bios
- ☐ Finalize poster design and one-sheet
- ☐ Update official poster, festival laurels version
- ☐ Prepare or confirm trailer, teaser, and festival clip
- ☐ Set up password-protected screener link (watermarked)
- ☐ Build press target list (minimum 15 contacts)
- ☐ Build industry target list (minimum 10 contacts)
- ☐ Research each contact: recent acquisitions, coverage, priorities

## Phase 3 — Days 60 to 31: Outreach

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- ☐ Send awareness emails to press list (Days 60 to 50)
- ☐ Send screener and press kit to press list (Days 49 to 35)
- ☐ Send initial outreach to distributor and industry list
- ☐ Contact festival programmer, thank them, ask for introductions

- Launch social media content arc, premiere announcement
- Confirm subject-specific media outreach if applicable
- Begin tracking responses and following up

## Phase 4 — Days 30 to 8: Momentum

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- ☐ Confirm screening time, venue, and format with festival
- ☐ Confirm DCP or file delivery with technical team
- ☐ Prepare and rehearse Q&A answers
- ☐ Confirm all industry meetings, send calendar invites
- ☐ Print materials and have backups: one-pagers and business cards
- ☐ Book flights and accommodation if not already done
- ☐ Build festival budget with all line items, including the dollar worksheet
- ☐ Continue social media momentum: subject content, countdown
- ☐ Send second touch to press contacts with story angle

## Phase 5 — Days 7 to 0: Arrival Ready

---

- ☐ Complete final week checklist
- ☐ Complete 14 days out final confirmation checklist
- ☐ Pack printed materials: one-pagers, cards
- ☐ Save all passwords, links, and emergency contacts offline
- ☐ Confirm all festival-week meetings in calendar
- ☐ Travel. Bring snacks.

### ◆ FESTIVAL WEEK

*Arrive at venue 45 minutes before screening. Confirm technical setup with projectionist, and skip through the film as you test. Introduce yourself to programmer and host. Conduct your Q&A; if one is not scheduled, ask for one. Stay for audience conversation, it often carries on in the lobby. Keep a daily contact log: name, organization, next step. Protect your energy, schedule time to rest. Follow up same-day on key meetings.*

## Post-Festival — Within 72 Hours

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- ☐ Send personal follow-ups to all key contacts
- ☐ Post festival wrap on social media
- ☐ Update press kit with awards, coverage, and positive reviews
- ☐ Send fresh screener to any distribution contacts who expressed interest

- Book any follow-up calls or meetings
- Review what worked. Update strategy for next festival, starting back at Phase 1.

# Quick Reference: Tools and Templates

*Everything you need in one place.*

## One-Pager Template: What to Include

- Film title and a one-line tagline
- Logline, one sentence
- Short synopsis, 75 words maximum
- Runtime and format
- Director, writer, editor, and producer names
- Festival selections and awards to date
- Contact email and website
- QR code linking to your press kit or trailer. Make it easy for people to reach you.

## Sample Industry Outreach Email

| SAMPLE<br>INDUSTRY<br>OUTREACH<br>EMAIL |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Subject                                 | [Film Title], World Premiere at [Festival Name], [Date]                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Body                                    | Hi [Name], I am the director/producer of [Film Title], a [runtime] documentary that will have its world premiere at [Festival Name] on [Date]. The film [one-sentence description of subject and angle]. It is in a similar space to [one comparable title they have handled]. The film includes [name notable person or hook if applicable]. I would welcome the chance to send you a screener, or to meet briefly during the festival if you will be attending. Best, [Your Name] [Contact   Website   Festival Dates] |

## Essential Tools & Platforms

| TOOL                 | PURPOSE                                          | COST                       |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| FilmFreeway.com      | Primary festival submission platform             | Free (fees per submission) |
| FilmFestivalLife.com | Alternative submission platform, discovery tool  | Free / paid tiers          |
| YouTube & Vimeo      | Screener hosting, password protection, analytics | ~\$20/month / free         |

| TOOL            | PURPOSE                                      | COST                                                                                    |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Canva Pro       | Poster, social graphics, EPK design          | ~\$13/month                                                                             |
| BeeHiive        | Email list building and audience newsletters | Free to 1000 contacts (check for specials or changes in price)                          |
| Google Drive    | Shared team folder for all press materials   | Free                                                                                    |
| Later or Buffer | Social media scheduling                      | \$15–\$18/month                                                                         |
| Notion (free)   | Festival tracking, submission calendar       | Free                                                                                    |
| WeTransfer Pro  | Sending large files to press and festivals   | ~\$12/month                                                                             |
| IMDbPro         | Industry connections, distributor research   | \$150/year – Make the investment. This is where the serious players review who you are. |



## Terminology You Should Know

| TERM                         | WHAT IT MEANS                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| World Premiere               | First public screening anywhere in the world. Most top-tier festivals require this. It can become complicated if you receive an acceptance requiring premiere status before your preferred festival has notified you. |
| North American Premiere      | First screening in North America. Useful after a European world premiere.                                                                                                                                             |
| DCP (Digital Cinema Package) | The standard theatrical file format for festival projection. Not the same as your editing file.                                                                                                                       |
| Press Screener               | A watermarked, password-protected version of your film for journalists to review.                                                                                                                                     |
| Sales Agent                  | Represents your film to distributors and buyers globally. Works on commission. Some charge upfront fees. Select carefully.                                                                                            |
| Commissioning Editor         | Broadcaster or streamer representative who can greenlight acquisition of your film, or your next.                                                                                                                     |
| Market Accreditation         | Separate from festival accreditation. Allows access to the industry market floor.                                                                                                                                     |
| Premiere Status              | Whether a festival counts as a world, international, or regional premiere. Affects future submission eligibility.                                                                                                     |
| Q&A / Panel                  | Post-screening audience conversation with filmmaker(s) and/or experts. Often the most important 15 minutes of a festival appearance.                                                                                  |

# A Final Word

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Ninety days sounds like a long time. It is not.

The filmmakers who use it well arrive at their festival feeling prepared, purposeful, and ready to be present and enjoy the experience. The ones who do not spend their festival weekend catching up, sending emails they should have sent weeks ago, scrambling for meetings that should have been booked in advance, and leaving without traction.

You have made a film, and it was accepted into a festival. These two facts alone are quite an achievement, given the competition for festival slots today. Your film clearly deserves to be seen and heard. But a great film playing in an empty theatre reaches nobody. The creative film work might be behind you, but the business side of the industry is now in front of you, equally as important, and if you follow a tried-and-true strategy, it can also be fun and very rewarding.

Your job now is to fill the room, with the right people, at the right time, with the right story already in their hands.

If you have been receiving multiple rejections, perhaps from every submission you applied for, it could be that you didn't choose a film festival perfectly in line with your film's subject, or that your film is not quite ready for the mass market. In which case, holding a private screening for friends and family could be in order. You can supply your questions to them as to what's working, what isn't, do they understand certain elements, are they engaged, where did they drop out if they aren't. You can learn so much from a test screening and if you go back into the film, tighten what's not working, then go back to your submission protocol.

*Hope this was a helpful guide on your festival journey. Good luck with your film's festival run. Drop us a line at [admin@Documentary411.com](mailto:admin@Documentary411.com) if there are any subjects you want us to cover with upcoming guides for documentary and independent filmmakers.*

*As you progress, update this guide, improve your performance, rinse and repeat!*

| *Start the clock. You have 90 days.*

**The best festival strategy is the one you execute.**

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## DOCUMENTARY411.COM

*The Definitive Resource for Documentary Filmmakers*

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